

The Oregon Trail

Put the westward journey in order along a 2,000-mile trail, and ask what it meant for the Native nations whose homelands the wagons crossed.

? Historical challenge

In the 1840s to the 1860s, hundreds of thousands of people loaded covered wagons and set out on the roughly 2,000-mile Oregon Trail to build new lives in the West. What did the journey look like from start to finish — and how did it change the land and the Native nations who already lived there? Follow the trail and put the journey in order.

1 Investigate

SOURCES 1

Oregon National Historic Trail — National Park Service

SECONDARY SOURCE

The route, its landmarks, and the wagon trains that traveled it.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What are three places along the trail, in order?
- How long did the journey take?

SOURCES 2

Trails to Utah and the Pacific: Diaries and Letters, 1846–1869 — Library of Congress

PRIMARY SOURCE

Real diaries and letters written by people on the overland journey.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What did a traveler worry about or hope for?
- What does a diary tell you that a map cannot?

SOURCES 3

War on the Oregon & California Trails — National Park Service

SECONDARY SOURCE

How the wagon traffic strained the Native nations along the route.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- How did the trail affect Native nations?
- Why might the same journey look different to different people?

2 Build your Event Map

Fill in the organizer from the evidence. Mark information with ①②③ to show which source it came from. Leave a space blank if the sources don't tell you.

THE EVENT

The Oregon Trail

1840s–1860s

Independence, Missouri to Oregon's Willamette Valley

1 Moment 1

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2 Moment 2

.....



3 Moment 3

.....



4 Moment 4

.....



5 Moment 5

.....



Important people / groups

Emigrant families — farmers seeking land and a new start

Trail guides and mountain men — led the wagon trains

Native nations (Pawnee, Lakota, Shoshone, Cayuse, Umatilla) — lived on the lands the trail crossed

Fur traders and fort keepers — traded supplies to passing travelers

Missionaries — among the first wagon parties west

Why did this matter?

One question I still have

Sources 1

Sources 2

Sources 3

3 Compare

- Compare your trail order with a partner. Did you put the moments in the same sequence?
- Which moment do you think was the hardest part of the journey? Why?

4 Expand

Your teacher will add context, vocabulary, and information the sources leave out. Add it to your map.

5 Revise

Go back to your Event Map. Add, correct, or reorganize based on the discussion.

6 Conclude

Tell the story of the Oregon Trail in your own words, in order. Use at least three moments and name at least two groups the journey affected — including the Native nations whose homelands it crossed.